

Free Arthritis Support Services in Northern Ireland

Practical NHS-backed advice on free arthritis support services northern ireland.

By **Living With Arthritis UK** · Reviewed by **Louis Maxwell** (HCPC Registered Physiotherapist) · 2026-07-24 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Free Arthritis Support Services in Northern Ireland

Quick Answer: Free arthritis support in Northern Ireland is available through Versus Arthritis (helpline 0800 5200 520), NHS Trust self-management programmes, community exercise classes, and Advice NI for benefits guidance — no referral needed for most services.

Living with arthritis in Northern Ireland doesn't mean facing it alone. A network of free, accessible services spans the region, from Belfast to the rural west.

Versus Arthritis in Northern Ireland

Versus Arthritis is the main charity supporting people with arthritis across Northern Ireland. Their free helpline (0800 5200 520) is staffed by trained advisors Monday–Friday. They also run peer support groups and free online self-management courses covering pain management, exercise, and fatigue.

Services Available

- Free helpline and email support
 - Peer support groups across Northern Ireland
 - Online self-management courses
 - Benefits and welfare rights signposting
 - Young people's services (under 25)
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NHS Self-Management Programmes



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All five Health and Social Care Trusts in Northern Ireland offer free self-management programmes for arthritis — typically 6-week courses covering pain management, gentle exercise, and navigating healthcare. Ask your GP for a referral or self-refer via your local Trust.

Free Exercise Classes

Many leisure centres across Northern Ireland offer free or reduced-cost exercise classes for people with long-term conditions. Hydrotherapy, Tai Chi, and seated exercise classes are commonly available. Contact your local leisure centre or GP for current listings.

Benefits Advice



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Advice NI (0800 915 4604) and Citizens Advice NI provide free, independent benefits advice including help with PIP, Attendance Allowance, and blue badge applications. Don't assume you won't qualify — always get a proper assessment.

Q&A;

Question: Do I need a GP referral for arthritis support in NI? **Short answer:** No — Versus Arthritis's helpline and groups are open access. NHS programmes can often be self-referred.

Question: Are services available in rural Northern Ireland? **Short answer:** Yes — online self-management courses and the free helpline are accessible anywhere in Northern Ireland.

Question: What if I can't afford transport to a support group? **Short answer:** Many groups now meet virtually. Ask Versus Arthritis about online alternatives for your area.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk